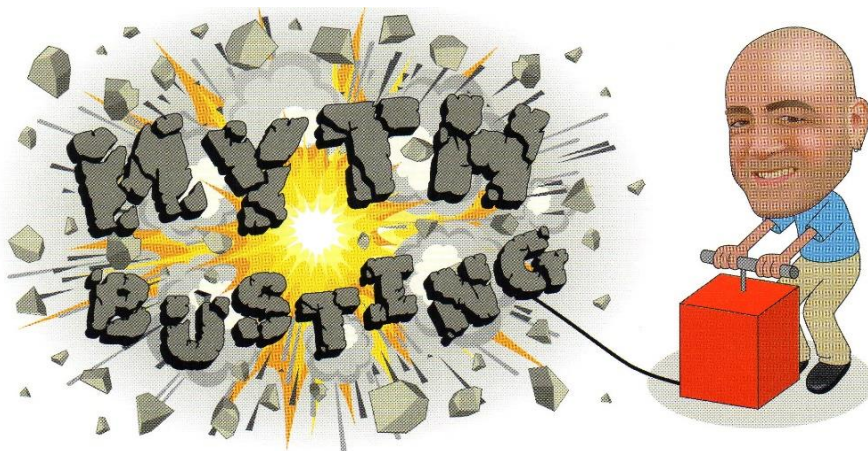


Dr Luke Beardon has been working for many years in the fields of autism and Asperger Syndrome. He completed his Doctoral thesis at Sheffield Hallam University and is now Senior Lecturer in autism at that university.

AuKids co-editors Tori and Debby heard Luke give a great talk about autism myths at an Autistic Intelligence conference in 2011. We loved it so much we wanted to give him a standing ovation, and were delighted when he published some of those views in an article for Asperger United magazine. We wanted to share it with you, so with everyone's permission, we nicked it. Here it is:

The myths of autism

Author's note: by writing autism I am including Asperger Syndrome; read on to find out why.

Author's note number two: I am writing about autism; I am categorically not writing about people who have autism and learning disabilities.

Author's note number three: if anything upsets you while reading this, please accept my apologies. All this is simply my opinion - open to question, absolutely. Nothing written here is intended to offend anyone.

This article is not (necessarily) fact. I do not claim to know all there is to know about autism; indeed, all I can claim is that I have a very keen interest in autistic people and have been working in 'the field' for 20 years or so. I probably know a bit more than the average man/woman on the street, but am more than happy to embrace the notion that in light of what there is yet to learn, I remain pretty ignorant.

The main point of this article is to try and highlight all the so-called 'facts' that are peddled about autism which lead to ignorance and misunderstanding. My intention is to question the building blocks upon which many professionals have based their knowledge, to create fissures in the foundations, and to urge the professional sector, simply, to think again.

I am somewhat constrained by a word limit. Well, that and the fact that I want to keep some of the detail to include in a publishable book, so I am not going into as much detail as I could. If you're a professional reading this and getting all indignant that I am suggesting that you are not as clued up as you should be, then you're probably one of the good ones.

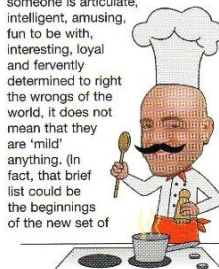
Myth: autism is a mental illness and/or a disease.

Ok, now I am not suggesting that in modern times people are still suggesting that autism is a mental illness or a disease (please don't tell me if they are, there's only so much ignorance a person can take). BUT - if this is the case, why are sets of criteria to be found in the International Classification of DISEASES and in the tome published by the American PSYCHIATRIC Association? Why do people often get referred to a PSYCHIATRIST for a diagnosis? Why are children often referred to Child and Adolescent MENTAL HEALTH Services (when there is no mental health issues evident)?

I am not suggesting for one moment that there are not good psychiatrists or mental health professionals out there, but what 'qualifies' them to work with autistic folk? Surely, the erroneous connotations of autism and mental illness/disease are not safe, nor sensible.

Myth: Asperger Syndrome is mild autism.

Excuse me while I grind my teeth and bang my head against this convenient brick wall. Just don't go there - ever. Just because someone is articulate, intelligent, amusing, fun to be with, interesting, loyal and fervently determined to right the wrongs of the world, it does not mean that they are 'mild' anything. (In fact, that brief list could be the beginnings of the new set of



AND ADD A DASH OF MILD AUTISM!

diagnostic criteria for Asperger Syndrome...). People are either autistic or they are not. The severity (i.e. the impact on the individual) will vary - dependent on numerous factors. So-called 'severely autistic' individuals may be supremely happy; so-called 'mildly autistic' individuals may be suicidal; you do the maths.

Myth: autism consists of a triad of impairments.

No, it doesn't. There are clear differences between the development of the autistic child and the predominant neurotype (PNT). Difference does not equal impairment. A different way of developing does not automatically mean the individual is impaired. Even if one might argue that a certain 'skill' is lacking, does that mean that the individual should be branded inferior?

The PNT have the 'skill' of chatting at length about essentially nothing: quite the coup, perhaps - but is it sensible? Many autistic people have the 'skill' of chatting at length about subjects that are extremely important to them; neither group is 'right' or 'wrong' - they simply possess a different set of skills.

Professionals must stop this branding of autistic people as impaired, deficient, or inferior in some way - as it's simply not true.

Of course many people face problems; those problems are a combination of the individual plus the environment - not simply because of the autism. In this case, surely the most sensible way forward is to change the environment, rather than somehow trying to change a person's autism (which ain't ever gonna happen).

Myth: autistic people are not sociable.

Oh, please, stop! Where did this bizarre and incalculably inaccurate notion come from? Some people with autism will happily while away their lives with no interest in others at all - and this should be perfectly acceptable (NB - please, if a person genuinely does not want to engage socially, don't try and force them to do so; it can be tantamount to bullying).

However, others might be hugely sociable, seeking company left, right, and centre. I suspect the wider PNT population is pretty similar. Sociability has nothing whatsoever to do with whether someone is autistic or not.

Myth: Asperger Syndrome is an intelligent form of autism.

Yes, people with Asperger Syndrome (AS) have average or above average intelligence. But, hang on, since when did autism denote intellectual impairment? If this was the case then surely the notion of 'co-morbidity' with a learning disability would be defunct? (I am deliberately using 'learning disability' here to denote intellectual impairment; as opposed to 'learning difficulty' - e.g. dyslexia - which has nothing whatsoever to do with intelligence). As far as I am aware, being autistic does not equate to being intellectually impaired - so the distinction between autism and AS can therefore be questioned. Unfortunately, it appears that some diagnosticians make the erroneous assumption that the diagnosis of autism implies intellectual impairment; in isolation this is simply not accurate.

If one (rightly, in my opinion) recognises that all autistic people are very much individuals, then such sub-classifications become highly questionable. What's wrong with simply identifying the individual as autistic, and leaving it at that? As a brief aside, is there anything more ludicrous than the notion of 'atypical autism' - if it wasn't so tragic it would be laughable.

Some other myths that clearly speak for themselves.

Autistic people:

- Can't look you in the eye
- Can't have a relationship
- Won't ever work
- Don't make excellent friends
- Will never be independent
- Are no good at sports
- Can't be good leaders
- Never show their emotions
- Are unfeeling and cold

The above are so obviously insanely ridiculous I shall not waste any more words expanding on them.

There is nothing that an autistic person cannot achieve in life as a result of being autistic. All sorts of other things

will come into play, of course, but autism alone is not a barrier to anything.

Those professionals who turn into soothsayers for parents, and who predict doom and gloom at every turn should be ashamed. They are not fortune-tellers, and there is no way of knowing at childhood what the future holds.

Yes, life is considerably tougher for most autistic people than their PNT peers, but it does not mean that dreams cannot be achieved.

I've merely skimmed the surface of the sea of ignorance that is evident 'out there'. By no means am I suggesting that all, or even most, clinicians and professionals are ignorant to a significant degree. However, I would stand by the sentiment that there is enough ignorance in enough clinicians and professionals for there to be a significant and negative impact on the lives of people with autism and their families. Clearly, this is unacceptable.

Until it is accepted that the autistic population is not one to fear, to marginalise, to brand inferior, or to decry as impaired, it seems obvious that there is still work to be done. Such ignorance is neither an excuse, nor is it in any way, bliss.

Luke Beardon

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Publications by Dr Luke Beardon

Dr Beardon co-wrote the ASPECT consultancy report, the largest consultation with adults with AS then undertaken (2007). He is co-editor of Asperger Syndrome and Employment: Adults Speak Out About Asperger Syndrome, Asperger Syndrome and Social Relationships: Adults Speak Out About Asperger Syndrome, and Aspies on Mental Health: Speaking for Ourselves

You can find out more about Autistic Intelligence by visiting www.autisticintelligence.org, or email talk@autisticintelligence.org

